

**Short Paper: The Heublein PM&C Case Study and
The Importance of Controlling Scope Creep**

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Scope control emerged as one of the most important themes in the Heublein PM&C case because the organization had a long history of capital projects that exceeded budget and drifted away from their intended objectives. As I analyzed the case, it became clear that the company's earlier emphasis on financial justification without strong planning and control created an environment where scope creep could easily take hold (Meredith et al., 2021). The development of the PM&C system was meant to correct these issues, but the case also highlighted several areas where scope creep could still occur if the system was not applied consistently. Reflecting on these risks helped me understand how scope creep develops in real organizational settings and what strategies are needed to prevent it (Lakey, 2026).

One possible area of scope creep involves the customization of the PM&C system across the four engineering groups. Heublein intentionally allowed each group to tailor the system to its operational environment, which supported adoption but also introduced the risk of expanding the system beyond its intended boundaries. If each group added features, reporting requirements, or process steps that were not part of the core framework, the system could become inconsistent and overly complex. This type of scope creep would undermine the purpose of creating a unified approach to planning and control. It could also increase training demands, complicate cross-group reporting, and reduce the clarity that the system was designed to provide. To prevent this, I would establish a clear baseline version of the PM&C system that all groups must follow, along with a structured change control process for any modifications (Kerzner, 2022). This would allow for thoughtful adaptation without allowing the system to fragment. If scope creep

did occur, I would manage it by conducting a cross-group review to identify which additions were beneficial and which needed to be rolled back to maintain consistency.

A second area of potential scope creep relates to the development of the Work Breakdown Structure. The case emphasized that Heublein created a highly detailed WBS that fully defined all deliverables before project initiation. While this level of clarity is a strength, it also creates the temptation to add new work packages as the project progresses, especially when stakeholders identify additional needs or improvements. Because the PM&C system was designed to address past failures, stakeholders might feel pressure to expand the WBS to include every possible enhancement. This would increase cost and schedule demands and could dilute the focus of the system. To prevent this, I would reinforce the principle that the WBS represents the approved scope at the time of project authorization and that any additions must go through formal evaluation (Meredith et al., 2021). If new work is proposed, it should be assessed for alignment with project objectives, resource availability, and organizational priorities. If scope creep did occur, I would manage it by revisiting the original objectives and determining whether the new work is essential or whether it should be deferred to a future phase.

Another area where scope creep could emerge is in the reporting and control system. The PM&C initiative placed significant emphasis on improving communication between corporate leadership and the engineering groups. While this is essential, there is a risk that reporting requirements could expand over time as stakeholders request additional metrics, formats, or review cycles. This type of administrative scope creep can burden project teams and reduce the time available for actual project execution. To prevent this, I would define a standard reporting structure that meets corporate needs without overwhelming the engineering groups. Any requests for additional reporting should be evaluated for necessity and impact. If reporting scope creep occurred, I

would manage it by consolidating redundant reports and reinforcing the purpose of the control system, which is to support decision-making rather than create unnecessary work (Kerzner, 2022).

Overall, the Heublein PM&C case illustrates how easily scope creep can develop even in well-designed systems. The complexity of the organization, the diversity of its engineering groups, and the pressure to improve project outcomes all create conditions where scope can expand unintentionally. Controlling scope creep requires clear baselines, structured change control, and consistent communication. It also requires a disciplined mindset that balances flexibility with adherence to project objectives. Through this analysis, I gained a deeper understanding of how scope creep affects project performance and how proactive planning and control can protect the integrity of a project. These insights will guide my approach to managing scope in future work, especially in environments where multiple stakeholders and operational differences create natural pressure points for change.

References

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- Meredith, J. R., Shafer, S. M., & Mantel, S. J. (2021). *Project management: A managerial approach* (10th ed.). Wiley.
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